FROM LAP TO TAP · THE SCIENCE

THE SCIENCE BEHIND THE PRACTICE

Why the moves in From Lap to Tap work: what the research says about stress, escalation, supervision, correction, praise, and repair, and where each one shows up in a classroom at School 63.

Every behavior has a root. Student behavior is not always a reflection of intellect, respect, motivation, or intent. Sometimes it is the visible evidence of a protection system trained by stress. The response in the moment is to the impact on learning, and the goal is always the return.

01 STRESS TAKES THE THINKING BRAIN OFFLINE

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Even mild stress that feels out of a person's control quickly weakens the prefrontal cortex, the part of the brain that holds instructions in mind, controls impulses, and thinks flexibly (Arnsten, 2009). A student in that state cannot reason the way the same student can when calm. Trauma explains the pattern. It does not remove accountability. It changes the intervention.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Short, calm, predictable language. Correct the action, not the child. Decisions such as reset seats are made before class, so nothing is negotiated in the moment.

02 EARLY, SMALL RESPONSES WORK BEST

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Acting-out behavior tends to follow a cycle: calm, trigger, agitation, acceleration, peak, de-escalation, and recovery (Colvin & Scott, 2015). Responses in the early phases, while the student can still respond, prevent most escalations. At the peak the priority is safety and disengagement. The recovery phase is the window for a debrief.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Least invasive first. Tally and keep moving. Request Tap In early, at Level 2. Hold the re-entry conversation once the student is calm.

03 MOVING, SCANNING, AND REMINDING PREVENTS PROBLEMS

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In an elementary school study, active supervision (moving, scanning, and interacting with students) combined with precorrection (a brief reminder of the expectation before a predictable trouble spot) reduced problem behavior during transitions (Colvin et al., 1997).

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

The compliance lap down the center aisle first. A What to Do direction at the launch. Proximity before behavior starts.

04 PRIVATE CORRECTION BEATS PUBLIC CORRECTION

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In a classic classroom study, soft reprimands that only the target student could hear reduced disruptive behavior more than loud reprimands heard by the whole class (O'Leary et al., 1970). A public correction adds an audience, and an audience gives the behavior a reason to continue.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Crouch and speak quietly. Correct a group without naming anyone. Hallway conversations side by side, with no audience.

05 PRAISE AHEAD OF CORRECTION RAISES TIME ON TASK

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

A study of 2,536 students in 151 kindergarten through sixth-grade classrooms in 19 schools found that students in classes with the highest praise-to-reprimand ratios spent 20 to 30 percent more time on task than students in classes with the lowest (Caldarella et al., 2020). On-task behavior reached about 60 percent at a 1:1 ratio, and the researchers suggest 2:1 or higher for more improvement. Attention is powerful in a classroom, and behavior tends to follow it.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Precise praise with a point. Lap marks on work done right. Positive narration before any correction. Planned ignoring of the last word, so attention goes to the students meeting the expectation.

06 REPAIR AFTER CONFLICT KEEPS STUDENTS ENGAGED

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

The Establish-Maintain-Restore approach trains teachers to build relationships, keep them, and repair them after a negative interaction (Cook et al., 2018). In a randomized trial with middle school teachers, brief training in this approach improved academically engaged time and reduced disruptive behavior (Duong et al., 2019). The sample was small, so the results are promising rather than final.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

The two-minute re-entry conversation. A clean start. One positive contact before the period ends.

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